Japan & Hong Kong
Master Itinerary

Friday 16 to Saturday 31 October 2026. Four legs, sixteen days. Master Itinerary V2, 7 October 2026.

Melbourne — CX524, lands 06:50 Sat 17 → **Shibuya** 4 nights — Nozomi 13, 07:55 Wed 21 → **Kyoto** 3 nights — Nozomi 16, 12:01 Sat 24 → **Hibiya** 3 nights — CX543, 10:10 Tue 27 → **Hong Kong** 3 nights — CX105, 00:30 Sat 31 → **Melbourne**

Booked **Bold black** is booked or fixed To book still needs a booking

Times are targets, not commitments, unless marked booked.

Flights Booked

OUT	MEL	15:25	Fri 16, T2	CX104	HKG	21:45	T1	3 h 35 min stopover	HKG 01:20 Sat 17, T1 → CX524 → NRT 06:50 T2
HOME	HND	10:10	Tue 27, T3	CX543	HKG	14:25	T1	3 nights Hong Kong	HKG 00:30 Sat 31, T1 → CX105 → MEL 12:30 T2

Trip calendar

Fri ● **16** Fly to Hong Kong	Sat ● **17** Land, Shibuya Sky	Sun ● **18** Meiji, Street Kart	Mon ○ **19** Stores, Shinjuku	Tue ○ **20** Tsukiji, Yokohama	Wed ● **21** Shinkansen, Nara	Thu ○ **22** Osaka day
Fri ○ **23** Arashiyama, Gion	Sat ● **24** Inari, fireworks	Sun ○ **25** Gardens, Ginza	Mon ● **26** teamLab, Asakusa	Tue ● **27** Fly to Hong Kong	Wed ○ **28** Pool, the Peak	Thu ○ **29** Big Buddha, city
Fri ● **30** Pool, Ozone, fly	Sat ● **31** 00:30 to Melbourne					

● Has a booked or fixed time ○ Flexible day All times are local, 24 hour

Itinerary Summary

The trip in four stays: what is fixed, and what can move. Tap any underlined name for its card.

■ Fixed or booked ⬚ Still to book ▭ Flexible

渋谷 Shibuya, Shinjuku and Yokohama

Leg 1 · Sat 17 to Wed 21 Oct · 4 nights · Sunset 17:00

Sequence Miyashita Park

	MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Fri 16		**CX104 15:25 from Melbourne**	**Hong Kong stopover, CX524 01:20**
Sat 17	**Land at Narita 06:50, N'EX to Shibuya**	Miyashita Park, Cat Street, Omotesando	**Shibuya Sky 16:00, dinner nearby or Ninja Tokyo**
Sun 18	Meiji Jingū, Harajuku	**Festival streets, Street Kart 16:00**	Shibuya dinner, or Sushi Hatsume
Mon 19	Omotesando vintage stores	Lunch, rest at the hotel	Shinjuku: Omoide Yokochō, Kabukichō, Golden Gai
Tue 20	Tsukiji breakfast	Yokohama waterfront, free afternoon	Chinatown dinner, pack

CAN SHIFT

- Shibuya Sky has backup slots on Mon 19 and Tue 20 if Saturday is clouded out.
- Kamakura can replace part of Tue 20.
- Loosest blocks: Sat 17 afternoon and Mon 19 morning.

京都 Kyoto, Nara and Osaka

Leg 2 · Wed 21 to Sat 24 Oct · 3 nights · Sunset 17:10 sequence KYOTO GOJO

	MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Wed 21	**Nozomi 07:55 to Kyoto, bags to Crosta**	Nara: kamameshi lunch, deer, Tōdai-ji	Check in, Pontochō dinner
Thu 22	Osaka Castle, Umeda Sky	Kuromon lunch, Horie shops	Shinsekai, Dōtonbori
Fri 23	Arashiyama bamboo 07:20, Nishiki lunch	Rest, Kiyomizu-dera 15:30	Yasaka, Gion dinner

CAN SHIFT

- Thu 22 and Fri 23 can swap, but Gion dinner is planned for Friday and Thursday is Jidai Matsuri day in Kyoto.
- The Pontochō and Gion dinners can swap.
- Nara can finish early if you are done.

銀座 Tokyo: Hibiya and Ginza

Leg 3 · Sat 24 to Tue 27 Oct · 3 nights · Sunset 16:55 The Blossom Hibiya

	MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Sat 24	Fushimi Inari 07:15, check out	**Nozomi 12:01 to Tokyo, check in**	**Odaiba fireworks, Hilton dinner**
Sun 25	East Gardens, Tokyo Station	Ginza car-free, shopping	Ginza dinner, Tokyo Tower or car meet
Mon 26	**teamLab Borderless 08:30**	Kappabashi, Sensō-ji, Skytree at dusk	Shimbashi, pack

CAN SHIFT

- Tokyo Tower works on Sun 25 night or after teamLab on Mon 26.
- teamLab can change date or time up to three times.
- Yūrakuchō can take any night.

香港 Hong Kong

Leg 4 · Tue 27 to Sat 31 Oct · 3 nights, late checkout · Sunset 17:50 Sheraton Hong Kong Hotel & Towers

	MORNING	AFTERNOON	EVENING
Tue 27	**CX543 10:10 from Haneda**	**Land 14:25, Sheraton, club lounge**	Aqua Luna cruise, Symphony of Lights
Wed 28	Sheraton pool, optional	Central, Peak Tram 15:45	Big dinner in Central
Thu 29	Ngong Ping cable car, Big Buddha	Sheung Wan, Man Mo Temple	Temple Street dinner
Fri 30	Sheraton pool, yum cha	Spare window, pack	**Ozone at sunset, CX105 00:30**

CAN SHIFT

- Wed 28, Thu 29 and Fri 30 can swap to suit the weather. The Peak has Fast Track only Friday to Sunday.
- Ozone can move to Thu 29, freeing Friday evening.

16 Friday

Melbourne to Hong Kong

Melbourne to Hong Kong, overnight to Tokyo

Car to Moonee Ponds, a lift to the airport, nine hours to Hong Kong, a late-night stopover, then the overnight flight to Tokyo.

11:15	Leave home, park the car in Moonee Ponds	Glenn picks up Cynthia on the way.
11:45	Lift to Melbourne Airport	About 15 to 20 minutes. Ask to be dropped at the Terminal 4 drop-off, which avoids the new forecourt arrangement.
12:10	Walk from Terminal 4 to Terminal 2	About 10 minutes with the bags. Terminal 2 is international departures.
12:25	Check in at the Cathay desks	Three hours before departure. Ask for the bags to be tagged through to Tokyo Narita, and collect both boarding passes.
13:15	Security and passport control	Then lunch airside.
14:45	Boarding	
15:25	**CX104 departs Melbourne** Booked	About 9 hours 20 minutes. Hong Kong is three hours behind Melbourne.
21:45	**Land in Hong Kong, Terminal 1** Booked	Follow Transfer, not Arrivals. You stay airside: transfer security only, no immigration, no bags to collect. Switch on the Ubigi eSIM (How-to 2).
22:30	Stopover: lounge or dinner	3 hours 35 minutes. The Plaza Premium Lounge near Gate 1 is open 24 hours, has showers and can be booked online ahead, from about HK$650 each. Or eat in the food hall.
00:40	At the gate	Check the screens for the gate first. Some gates are a train ride away, so leave the lounge 50 minutes before departure.
01:20	**CX524 departs for Tokyo Narita** Booked	About 4 hours 30 minutes. Tokyo is one hour ahead. Sleep if you can.

The night runs straight on into Saturday 17, which starts with the 06:50 landing at Narita.

17 Saturday
Shibuya

Arrive and wander Shibuya

No trains after the airport, just a slow loop on foot from the hotel while you wait for the room. Only the landing and Shibuya Sky are fixed. The other times are a guide.

06:50	**Land at Narita** Booked	CX524, Terminal 2. Visit Japan Web ready. Check you each get the landing sticker, then scan it into Visit Japan Web (How-to 4).
08:15	Narita Express to Shibuya	Buy the ticket at Narita, on a train that stops at Shibuya (How-to 5). About 80 minutes.
10:00	Shibuya Station, bags to the hotel	Hachikō exit, lobby on 4F (How-to 6). Ask about early check-in: free if a room is ready, bags held until then.
10:30	Miyashita Park and Cat Street	The rooftop park above the hotel, where the festival is on, then Cat Street. If shattered, stop here.
12:30	Omotesando	Lunch wherever looks good. Omotesando Hills, Tod's and Dior to look up at. Prada Aoyama optional.
13:45	Wander back into Shibuya	Hachikō, the Scramble Crossing, Center-gai.
14:45	Supplies, then check in if the room is ready	Don Quijote and 7-Eleven for supplies. No room yet: bags stay at the desk until after Shibuya Sky.
16:00	**Shibuya Sky** Booked	Seven minutes' walk. Pockets only, no bags (How-to 7). Sunset about 17:00, then the lights.
18:30	Dinner close by	Nonbei Yokochō or Dōgenzaka, then an early night.
19:00	Optional: Ninja Tokyo dinner To book	Instead of dinner close by: a ninja village underground in Ōtemachi. From ¥13,200. Hanzōmon line, 20 minutes.

Which day is Shibuya Sky?

Three slots are booked: Saturday 16:00, plus Monday and Tuesday sunsets as backups. Check the forecast on arrival and pick one, then see whether the other two can be cancelled or changed. That one choice sets Monday and Tuesday. If Sky stays on Saturday, the better weather day of the two goes to Tsukiji and Yokohama.

Shibuya Sky is on	Monday 19	Tuesday 20
Saturday Clear on arrival. The default	Shinjuku, or swap for weather	Tsukiji and Yokohama, or swap for weather
Monday Saturday is out, Monday is clear	Shinjuku, with a sunset break for Shibuya Sky	Tsukiji and Yokohama
Tuesday Only Tuesday works	Tsukiji and Yokohama	Shinjuku, with a sunset break for Shibuya Sky

18 Sunday
Shibuya

Meiji Jingū, Harajuku, the festival, Street Kart

A light day on foot. The shrine and Harajuku in the morning, the festival on the walk home, then karting over the bay at golden hour.

09:00	Slow breakfast	
09:45	Meiji Jingū	15 minutes' walk from the hotel. Forest paths and the big torii.
11:00	Takeshita Street and the Harajuku back lanes	Busy on a Sunday. Walk it once, then duck into the lanes behind.
12:15	Lunch in Harajuku	
13:15	Cat Street back into the festival streets	Dōgenzaka, Bunkamura-dori, 109. The streets close for stages on Sunday. Dip in and out rather than chasing set times.
14:45	Head to the Street Kart meeting point	Check the location on the booking and allow the travel time.
15:30	Arrive 30 minutes early	Fully closed shoes on. Physical licence card, physical International Driving Permit and passports in hand. No digital copies.
16:00	**Street Kart, Rainbow Bridge route** Booked	Golden hour over the bay.
Evening	Back to Shibuya, nice dinner	Option: Sushi Hatsume in Ebisu, one stop away. 22-course omakase, ¥10,890 each, 19:30 seating. Book ahead if you want it.

If Street Kart can't run today

Today
Spend the extra time in Shibuya. Stay on the festival streets through the afternoon, then dinner as planned.

Backup
Rebook for Sunday 25 or Monday 26 October, when you are staying in Hibiya. It is on that side of town. Sunday slots into the Ginza day and Monday into the free afternoon. See both days.

19 Monday
Shibuya

Omotesando stores, Shinjuku after dark

Monday 19. The Shinjuku day

A slow start, the stores, a rest at the hotel, then Shinjuku after dark, west to east. Rain barely touches this day.

09:30	Late breakfast	A slow start. Nothing is booked today.
11:00	Omotesando and Aoyama vintage luxury	Until 14:00. The secondhand luxury boutiques either side of the avenue. All open at 11:00 except Casanova at 12:00 (How-to 9). Passports for tax-free. G has his own options (How-to 10).
14:00	Lunch in Omotesando	
15:00	Back to the hotel	A 20 minute walk. Drop the bags, feet up.
16:45	Shinjuku: the 3D cat at the east exit	JR Yamanote from Shibuya, about 7 minutes. The giant cat billboard at dusk.
17:30	Omoide Yokochō	Yakitori and a drink, grazing across two or three counters before they fill (How-to 11).
18:45	Godzilla head, Kabukichō and Kabukichō Tower	Through the underpass to the east side. Neon at full strength. Ignore touts: never follow anyone off the street into a bar.
20:00	Hanazono Shrine, then Golden Gai	The shrine is beside Golden Gai, lit at night. In Golden Gai: cash, a cover charge, and look for English menus. Regulars-only means move on (How-to 11).
21:30	Fukutoshin line home	From Shinjuku-sanchōme, the closest station to Golden Gai. Direct to Shibuya, about 5 minutes.

Weather rule: the better day of Monday and Tuesday gets Tsukiji and Yokohama, and the other gets this day. On a wet morning teamLab can move here (How-to 8), or try the Sumo show in Shibuya, times to check. Of interest if plans change: the Government Building deck about 16:15 for dusk, and the Isetan food hall. Running early: go into Shinjuku sooner and wander the station and the east side streets. Shinjuku Gyoen is the park to see, on a Tuesday only.

Monday 19. If Shibuya Sky is on Monday

Same day, with a sunset break back in Shibuya. Three changes:

- Leave the stores by 14:00, then lunch and bags to the hotel as planned.
- Shibuya Sky about 16:15, the booked sunset slot. Bags stay at the hotel (How-to 7).
- Then JR to Shinjuku about 17:45 and pick the plan up at Omoide Yokochō. The 3D cat comes after dinner.

Monday 19. If Shibuya Sky is on Tuesday

Monday and Tuesday swap. Today becomes the Tsukiji and Yokohama day, exactly as written for Tuesday, and the Shinjuku day moves to Tuesday.

20 Tuesday
Shibuya

Tsukiji market and Yokohama

Tuesday 20. The Tsukiji and Yokohama day

Breakfast at Tsukiji Outer Market in its best window, then a long Yokohama day: the waterfront, the harbour walk and Chinatown. The outdoor day: give it the better weather of Monday and Tuesday.

07:30	Leave the hotel for Tsukiji	Ginza line to Ginza, then the Hibiya line two stops to Tsukiji. About 30 minutes, at the commuter peak.
08:15	Tsukiji Outer Market breakfast	The best window, before the 10:00 rush. Tamagoyaki, tuna, grilled scallop and uni, strawberry daifuku. Eat at the stall. Then Namiyoke shrine.
10:15	Train to Yokohama	About an hour. Hibiya line to Naka-meguro, then the Tōyoko line through to Minatomirai. Check the route on the day.
11:30	Sakuragichō, Air Cabin, Minato Mirai waterfront	The cable car across the harbour, Red Brick Warehouses, the skyline. No rush today.
13:00	Lunch, then a free afternoon on the waterfront	Ideas in Extras, Yokohama.
16:30	Harbour walk to Chinatown, dinner	At dusk. Idea: the footbath at The Wharf House on the way (How-to 22). Dinner from 17:30.
19:30	Train home from Motomachi-Chūkagai	Runs straight through to Shibuya, about 40 minutes, no change.
20:30	Pack	Tomorrow is an early start.

Alternatives: the market also fits Mon 19 before the stores open, or Mon 26 with teamLab moved to 13:30. Closed Sundays and Wednesdays.

Tuesday 20. Alternative morning: Kamakura

Swap the market morning for the coast, temples and the Great Buddha. Join the plan above about 14:30. The market goes to Monday 19 morning, or drops out.

- 08:00 JR Shōnan-Shinjuku line to Kamakura, about an hour, direct.
- 09:15 Tsurugaoka Hachimangū and Komachi-dōri.
- 11:00 Enoden, the little seaside train, to Hase for Hase-dera and the Great Buddha.
- 12:30 Lunch in Hase or Kamakura.
- 14:00 JR to Yokohama, about 25 minutes.

Tuesday 20. If Shibuya Sky is on Tuesday

Monday and Tuesday swap. Tsukiji and Yokohama moves to Monday, and today becomes the Shinjuku day as written for Monday. Four changes:

- Today runs as written for Monday: late breakfast, the stores from 11:00, lunch at 14:00.
- Back to the hotel about 15:00 to pack and leave the bags, then Shibuya Sky at 16:00, the booked backup slot.
- JR to Shinjuku about 18:00 for Omoide Yokochō, the 3D cat, Kabukichō and Golden Gai.
- Train back by about 21:30. It is a 05:55 wake for the Shinkansen.

21 Wednesday

Shibuya to Kyoto

Shibuya to Kyoto, straight out to Nara

An early start with the bags on the train. Then Nara, which is flat, outdoors and forgiving, which is what a travel day wants.

05:55	Wake, final pack, check out by 06:20	
06:30	Taxi to Shinagawa, Kōnan exit	About 20 to 25 minutes. Book it at the front desk the night before. The Yamanote line from Shibuya is the fallback (How-to 12).
07:00	Shinagawa, ekiben and coffee	Breakfast on the train. Early on purpose: this is the train you cannot miss.
07:55	**Nozomi 13 to Kyoto** Booked	Car 9, seats 16-C and 16-D, Green Car with oversized baggage area. Fuji on the right at about 08:30.
10:00	**Kyoto Station** Booked	
10:15	Bags to Crosta Kyoto, level B1	Below the JR Central Gate, open until 20:00. Take passports and valuables out first (How-to 13).
10:40	Kintetsu limited express to Nara	South side of the station, about 10 minutes from Crosta. Seats at the machine, about ¥1,280 each (How-to 24).
11:15	Kintetsu Nara, up into Higashimuki arcade	Covered to Sanjō-dōri. Nakatanidō mochi pounding at the end.
11:30	Lunch: Kamameshi Shizuka	Iron-pot rice cooked to order, about 20 minutes. Ten minutes east, beside Isuien. No bookings. Long queue: a kakinoha box instead.
12:45	Into Nara Park for the deer	Straight onto the lawns towards Kasuga, calmer than the Tōdai-ji gate. Kōfuku-ji's pagoda is wrapped until 2034. Deer crackers about ¥200.
13:35	Kasuga Taisha and the lantern path	Up through the stone lanterns to the shrine front. No need to pay to go inside.
14:25	Tōdai-ji and the Great Buddha	Twenty minutes north along the hill, in through the Nandaimon gate. The school groups have cleared. Open until 17:30.
15:30	Nigatsu-dō	Ten minutes uphill behind the main hall. A west-facing balcony over the city, best in the late light. Free.
16:15	Walk down to Kintetsu Nara	About 20 minutes downhill past the Tōdai-ji gate. Raining or tired: a taxi from the gate, or the loop bus with Suica.
16:45	Kintetsu limited express back	Kyoto by about 17:20. Collect the bags.
17:25	Kyoto Station building	The staircase lights up at dusk. The free Sky Garden faces Kyoto Tower.
17:45	Walk to sequence KYOTO GOJO, check in	About 15 minutes straight up Karasuma-dōri with the bags, or one subway stop to Gojō (How-to 13).
19:00	Pontochō dinner, casual, no booking	About 20 minutes on foot, or one subway stop to Shijō. Walk in along Kiyamachi-dōri.
20:30	Optional: Kamo River and the Shirakawa canal	Shijō Bridge is at the end of the alley, Shirakawa seven minutes beyond. Taxi home.

Stags are pushy: feed the does. Alternative: JR Nara line on Suica, 20 minutes from the park (How-to 24). Pontochō and Gion dinners can swap.

22 Thursday
Kyoto

Osaka, castle to Dōtonbori

A whole day in Osaka, no Universal. The castle up close first, Umeda Sky mid morning, a market lunch, the shops, the lion head, Shinsekai at dusk and Dōtonbori at night. One deck, not two.

07:00	To Kyoto Station, then JR to Osaka	One subway stop or a 15 minute walk. JR special rapid to Osaka Station, about 30 minutes, then the Osaka Loop Line to Osakajōkōen for the castle (How-to 14).
08:30	Osaka Castle, up close	In by Aoya-mon to Gokuraku-bashi: the tower over the inner moat walls. Then to its foot, not inside. Takeaway breakfast on a bench.
09:35	Tanimachi line to Higashi-Umeda	From Tanimachi 4-chōme, on the west side of the castle. Buy the one-day Enjoy Eco Card at the metro station, about ¥820. It covers the Osaka Metro all day, not JR.
10:15	Umeda Sky deck	Two towers joined by a floating escalator. About 15 minutes on foot from Higashi-Umeda.
12:00	Kuromon Ichiba	Midōsuji line down to Namba. Grilled scallops, uni, tuna cut in front of you. This is lunch, not a snack stop.
13:15	Horie, Amerikamura and Shinsaibashi	The vintage and secondhand luxury run: Kindal Horie, ALLU, KOMEHYO. Orange Street for furniture, design shops and coffee when you want it calmer. Passports for tax-free.
15:30	Namba Yasaka Shrine	The giant lion head. Ten minutes is enough. Closes about 17:00.
16:15	Janjan-Yokochō into Shinsekai	In at dusk as the signs come on. Sunset is 17:05. Tsūtenkaku, and kushikatsu under the tower, kept to a snack.
18:30	Dōtonbori	Buy Tombori River Cruise tickets when you arrive and ride after dark (How-to 15). The Glico Running Man photo platform is at the Nanohana cosmetics shop, directly opposite the sign. Eat standing up.
20:30	Hōzenji Yokochō	Two streets back. Stone lanes, lanterns and the mossy Mizukake Fudō. A quiet drink after the noise.
21:30	Home by Midōsuji line and JR	Namba to Umeda, then the JR special rapid from Osaka Station to Kyoto, about 30 minutes. One subway stop to Gojō, or a 15 minute walk (How-to 14).

Weather fallback
If the morning is clouded out, do Umeda Sky at night instead, open to 22:30. Or work Abeno Harukas 300 back in at sunset, ten minutes on foot from Shinsekai.

Running late
Shorten the castle first, then the shops. Protect lunch at Kuromon, the lion head before 17:00 and Shinsekai at dusk.

Left out
Nakazakichō, Nakanoshima and Abeno Harukas 300. Thursday and Friday can swap if they must. See The four legs.

23 Friday
Kyoto

Kyoto, west to east

Arashiyama at dawn while it is empty, an early market lunch and a rest, Higashiyama in the late light, Gion for dinner.

06:45	Leave the hotel	One subway stop or a 15 minute walk to Kyoto Station, then the JR Sagano line to Saga-Arashiyama. About 35 minutes door to door.
07:20	Bamboo grove	Genuinely empty before eight. This is the whole reason for the early start.
08:30	Tenryū-ji as it opens	The pond garden backs onto the bamboo and most people walk straight past it.
09:30	Ōkōchi Sansō villa, or Togetsukyō bridge and the river path	Pick one. The villa includes matcha.
10:15	Coffee and a snack in Arashiyama	No sit-down breakfast. Lunch is early.
10:45	Back to the centre	About 40 minutes. The Hankyu line to Karasuma, changing at Katsura, comes out beside the market.
11:30	Nishiki Market lunch	Ahead of the lunch crush. Rolled omelette, tofu doughnuts, pickles, skewers. Eat at the stall. Aritsugu, the old knife maker, is at the east end.
12:45	Walk to the hotel and rest	About 15 minutes south. Two hours of rest, or slack if the morning ran long.
15:30	Kiyomizu-dera	Taxi from the hotel at 15:15, about 10 minutes. The top of Higashiyama, the old eastern hills. The stage view over the city is the thing. Closes 18:00.
16:30	Down through Sannenzaka and Ninenzaka	Downhill from Kiyomizu, not uphill from Gion. Steep stone steps, slippery in rain. Shops start closing about 17:30.
17:10	Yasaka Pagoda at sunset	Two minutes off Ninenzaka. The five storey pagoda above the lane roofs.
17:30	Yasaka shrine, then down into Gion	Lanterns lit. Then Hanamikoji, and the Shirakawa canal if you missed it on Wednesday.
18:30	Dinner in Gion To book	The one special dinner in Kyoto. Book before you leave Melbourne. Friday walk-ins here are hard.

Getting to Higashiyama
The hotel is in the centre, not at the foot of the hill. Taxi up to Kiyomizu-dera, then the afternoon runs downhill on foot to Gion. Taxi home after dinner, about 10 minutes.

Dinner swap
Pontochō on Wednesday, Gion tonight. If the Gion table you want is only free on Wednesday, swap them. Pontochō is five minutes past Gion, over the bridge.

Autumn colour
Late October is green and early gold, not red. Kyoto's maples turn mid to late November.

24 Saturday

Kyoto to Hibiya

Fushimi Inari, back to Tokyo, fireworks night

Fushimi Inari at first light, the train back to Tokyo, an hour at the hotel, then fireworks over the bay from Odaiba. Dinner comes after the show, so the trains have cleared by the time you leave.

06:30	To Kyoto Station, then JR Nara line to Inari	One subway stop or a 15 minute walk to the station. Inari is two stops, about 5 minutes, and the shrine gate faces the platform. Sunrise is around 06:10.
07:15	Fushimi Inari	Walk far enough up the mountain to lose everyone. A crush by ten.
09:45	Back to the hotel, shower and repack	
10:30	Check out and walk to Kyoto Station	About 15 minutes with the bags, or one subway stop (How-to 16).
11:15	Kyoto Station. Ekiben and coffee	Lunch on the train buys you the morning. Fair trade.
12:01	**Nozomi 16 to Tokyo Station** Booked	Car 9, seats 1-C and 1-D, Green Car with the oversized baggage area. Seat D is the Fuji side, on your left this time.
14:15	**Tokyo Station, Yaesu side taxi rank** Booked	Allow 15 minutes to clear the station. Saturday afternoon is busy. Ten to fifteen minutes to the hotel, roughly ¥1,500 to ¥2,000.
15:00	Check in at Hotel The Blossom Hibiya	Pre-registered if the hotel allows it, so arrival is keys only. An hour to shower and change. Take a layer, the bay is cool after dark.
16:00	Walk to Shimbashi, Yurikamome to Daiba	About 15 minutes on the train. Go early, it gets crowded by 17:00. Sit at the front for the Rainbow Bridge loop.
16:30	Hilton Tokyo Odaiba	Next to Daiba station. Collect the wristbands and find the viewing area before it fills. Sunset is about 16:55.
17:30	**Fireworks from the Hilton's private viewing area** Booked	Until 19:00. Seascape package, wristband needed.
19:30	**Seascape dinner buffet** Booked	Until 21:15.
21:15	Optional: Odaiba Statue of Liberty	A few minutes' walk from the Hilton on the waterfront, lit up with Rainbow Bridge behind it. Skip it if you are done.
21:45	Yurikamome back to Shimbashi, walk to the hotel	The post-show rush is over by the time dinner ends. A taxi is quick if the platform is packed.

A long day: 06:30 start, back about 22:30. The hour at the hotel and a seated dinner are what make it work, so don't trade either away.

25 Sunday
Hibiya

Slow start, gardens, then Ginza until you're done

A sleep in, the gardens and Tokyo Station before midday, then the rest of the day and night in Ginza at your own pace. No bookings.

08:30	Slow breakfast near the hotel	The easy slot for a load of washing. Details in the appendix (How-to 17).
09:15	Imperial Palace East Gardens	About 15 minutes' walk. Opens 09:00, free. Old castle keep foundations and the Ninomaru garden. Take your time.
10:45	Tokyo Station, Marunouchi side	The red brick façade. KITTE's rooftop garden looks straight down on it. Coffee or a bite in the station.
11:30	Tokyo International Forum	On the walk from the station into Ginza. Free to walk through the glass hall. Go up to the top walkway.
12:00	Ginza goes car-free	Chūō-dōri is pedestrian only until 17:00. You're already into the shopping.
Afternoon	Department stores and shopping	Mitsukoshi, Ginza Six, Matsuya, Dover Street Market, Itoya, vintage luxury resale, which is the fallback if the Omotesando run on Monday 19 fell short. Maison Hermès, Mikimoto Ginza 2 and the Wakō clock tower as you go. Passports.
Late arvo	Rooftop gardens	Ginza Six's rooftop garden and Mitsukoshi's rooftop terrace. A good break as the light goes.
Evening	Eat in the complexes	Restaurant floors trade later than the shops. No booking, eat wherever appeals.
19:30	Optional: Tokyo Tower lit up, or a car meet	Tower: 10 minutes by taxi, Zōjō-ji gate. Or a JDM car tour to Daikoku from the hotel, 20:00 to 23:00 (How-to 23).
When done	Walk back to the hotel	Five to ten minutes.

Browse the big stores before about 20:00 and eat after. Sunday restaurant floors queue around 18:30 to 19:30, so eat a touch earlier or later. Many smaller Ginza bars and restaurants close on Sundays. If it is wet, drop the gardens and start in Ginza earlier, or move teamLab to this morning (How-to 8).

If Street Kart moved to today

One of two backups for Sunday 18
Aim for the same 16:00 golden hour slot. Leave the Ginza shopping a little early, about 14:45, and arrive 30 minutes ahead with International Driving Permit and passports. Adjust to the slot you get. Closed shoes, physical licence and permit.

Afterwards
Back to Ginza for the late shops and dinner in the complexes. Shop floors close about 20:00 and the restaurant floors trade later. The rooftop gardens at dusk are what you give up.

26 Monday
Hibiya

teamLab first thing, Asakusa, Shimbashi

First session at teamLab, a look at Tokyo Tower, then across town to Kappabashi while the shops are open, Sensō-ji as the crowds ease and the Skytree at dusk, before a casual last night.

07:50	Leave the Blossom	About 25 minutes on foot via Toranomon to Azabudai Hills. Taxi if it is wet.
08:30	**teamLab Borderless, first session** Booked	Arrive a little early to be among the first in. Allow about two hours. The booking can change date or time up to three times.
10:40	Sky Room Café, or Tokyo Tower and Zōjō-ji	Optional. Coffee on 33F beside the tower, or a 10 minute walk to the temple gate below it.
11:30	Hibiya line, then Ginza line to Tawaramachi	From Kamiyachō, change at Ginza. About 30 minutes. From Zōjō-ji, the Asakusa line runs direct from Daimon.
12:00	Kappabashi kitchenware street, then lunch	While the shops are open, most close about 17:00. Knives and ceramics. Lunch in Asakusa about 13:30.
14:45	Sensō-ji, Kaminarimon, Nakamise street	Ten minutes east. If Nakamise is jammed, take the side lanes to the main hall.
16:15	Skytree views at dusk, no deck	Free terrace at the Asakusa Culture Tourist Information Centre, then Azuma-bashi bridge. Sunset 16:55.
17:30	Ginza line back to Shimbashi	Direct from Asakusa, about 15 minutes. Half pack at the hotel.
19:00	Shimbashi, no booking	Five minutes from the hotel. Wander the lanes around the tracks, eat wherever looks good. Weeknights are when it's liveliest.
Late	Back to the hotel	Finish packing and settle the bill. Tomorrow is the 06:38 train (How-to 18).

Why Asakusa is today
Ceramics and knives bought now go home without a trip through Kyoto. Knives fly in checked bags only. And the market on Tuesday comes before you are sushied out. Shops first as they close about 17:00, temple later as the crowds ease.

Other shapes
Tsukiji can come back here at 08:00 with teamLab moved to 13:30, and Asakusa returns to Tuesday 20. If teamLab moved for wet weather, start in Asakusa about 10:00.

If Street Kart moved to today

The last backup, after Sunday 18 and Sunday 25
Strip the day to make 16:00: teamLab, Kappabashi, a short Sensō-ji, leave Asakusa by 14:30. Arrive 30 minutes ahead. Closed shoes, passports, physical licence and International Driving Permit.

Afterwards
Straight to Shimbashi for dinner. Pack before you go out.

27 Tuesday

Hibiya to Hong Kong

Haneda to Hong Kong, harbour night

An early train to Haneda with the bags, then the first Hong Kong night on the harbour: a junk boat cruise timed for the 20:00 Symphony of Lights. No pool today, because the sun is nearly gone by check-in.

05:45	Wake, shower, final pack	
06:22	Leave the hotel, walk to Shimbashi	About 8 minutes with the bags. Asakusa line, platform 1.
06:38	Airport Rapid Limited Express to Haneda Terminal 3	Direct, about 25 minutes. The backup is the 06:45 Express. Avoid trains bound for Nishi-magome (How-to 18).
07:15	Check in at the Cathay desks	Three hours before departure.
07:45	Security and immigration	Usually quick, but allow for a queue.
08:15	Breakfast airside	Spend leftover yen and IC card balance here.
09:40	Boarding	
10:10	**CX543 departs Haneda** Booked	Terminal 3. Hong Kong is one hour behind Tokyo.
14:25	**Land in Hong Kong** Booked	Terminal 1. Allow 45 to 60 minutes for immigration, bags and customs.
15:20	Red urban taxi to the Sheraton	20 Nathan Road, Tsim Sha Tsui. 35 to 45 minutes, roughly HK$300 to 350 with tolls and bag fees. Carry some cash.
16:15	Check in at the Sheraton	Ask two things at the desk: whether pool sessions need booking, and the club lounge hours. Friday's late checkout is already confirmed to 18:00.
17:15	Club lounge	Drinks and canapés as the harbour lights come on. Sunset is about 17:50.
18:50	Walk to Tsim Sha Tsui Public Pier 1	Ten minutes from the hotel, behind the Cultural Centre. Queue early for the best seats.
19:30	Aqua Luna harbour cruise To book	45 minutes on a red-sail junk, one drink included. Confirm the sailing is running before you fly.
20:00	A Symphony of Lights	The nightly harbour light show. Lasers, searchlights and LED screens on the towers along both shores, set to music, for about ten minutes. You watch it from the boat.
20:20	Avenue of Stars	Off the boat and along the Tsim Sha Tsui promenade. Handprints, the Bruce Lee statue and the full Island skyline.
20:45	Dinner in Tsim Sha Tsui	Close to the promenade and the hotel.
Late	Bar, or Temple Street night market	Only if you have the energy.

Taxi instead in Tokyo
The fallback if the train looks wrong on the day. About 25 minutes. Even a 07:15 taxi gets you to Haneda 2.5 hours before departure.

Instead of the taxi in Hong Kong
First check whether the Agoda booking includes an airport pickup. Otherwise the Airport Express to Kowloon Station, then a 5 to 10 minute taxi, costs about the same for two with more bag handling.

If the show has ended or the cruise is full
Watch from the Tsim Sha Tsui promenade, five minutes from the hotel. It faces the Hong Kong Island towers, which is the better side. Your harbour view room faces the same way.

28 Wednesday
Hong Kong

Pool, Hong Kong Island and the Peak

The main Island day and the main night out. Up the Peak early by tram, time at the top through sunset, taxi down.

09:00	Lounge breakfast	
09:45	Sheraton pool until about 13:00	Optional. This is the best block for sun. Read, tan, swim. Light lunch at the hotel.
13:30	Star Ferry to Central	Ten minutes across the harbour.
14:00	Graham Street Market, Tai Kwun, PMQ, Mid-Levels escalator	The old street market first, then design and architecture, all within a few blocks.
15:45	Peak Tram up To book	Standard one-way ticket, prebooked. Sit on the right going up. Then Lugard Road for the best free view, and take your time at the top (How-to 19).
17:50	Sunset at the Peak	Stay while the city lights come on.
18:45	Taxi down	Tram seats face backwards on the way down, so skip it.
19:30	Dinner in Central or SoHo To book	The big dinner of the trip. Book ahead.
Late	Bars in Central	Taxi back through the tunnel, or a late train to the hotel. The MTR from Central to Tsim Sha Tsui is two stops and runs until after midnight.
Optional	Or the old tram and the Star Ferry home	Instead of the taxi or train: ride the old tram from Central to Wan Chai, upper deck, about 15 minutes with the neon on. Then take the Star Ferry home from Wan Chai. It adds about half an hour. The last ferry from Wan Chai is 23:00, so leave the bars by about 22:15.

Fast Track
Klook's Peak Tram Fast Track only runs Friday to Sunday. If the Peak moves to Friday 30, that is the ticket to buy.

29 Thursday
Hong Kong

Ngong Ping cable car, Big Buddha, then the city

Out to Lantau for the first cable car, back to the Island for lunch and the Sheung Wan shops, a rest at the hotel, then Temple Street at night.

08:00	Lounge breakfast	
08:45	Train to Tung Chung	About 50 minutes, one change.
10:00	Ngong Ping 360 cable car up To book	Crystal cabin, Klook voucher (How-to 20). First car, shortest queues. 25 minutes.
10:30	Big Buddha, Po Lin Monastery, Wisdom Path	268 steps up. Skip most of the village.
12:45	Cable car down	
13:20	Train to Hong Kong Station, Central	About 30 minutes.
14:00	Lunch in Central or Sheung Wan	Yum cha is Friday's lunch, so eat whatever appeals here.
15:00	Sheung Wan shops	Hollywood Road, Cat Street antiques, vintage and resale. Don't forget Man Mo Temple, on Hollywood Road as you pass. Ten minutes inside.
16:15	Egg tart and coffee stop	
17:00	Star Ferry from Central to Tsim Sha Tsui	On the water close to sunset, about 17:50.
18:15	Optional: Ozone at the Ritz-Carlton	Friday is the plan. If you go tonight instead: quick change first, short taxi to ICC, and Friday evening is free.
19:30	Temple Street dinner and night market	Claypot rice or street-side seafood, then browse the stalls. A 15 minute walk from the hotel.
21:30	Back at the hotel	Or a bar nearby.

Notes and optionals for Thursday

If you skip the cable car and Big Buddha
Sleep in, then relax at the Sheraton pool until about 14:00, or take the Star Ferry across late morning and wander Central. Join the plan at lunch or at the Sheung Wan shops at 15:00.

Gentler start
Leave at 09:45 for an 11:00 cable car. Queues are longer, lunch moves to about 15:00 and the Sheung Wan shops shrink to an hour.

Weather
The cable car stops in high wind and the views vanish in low cloud. Check the forecast the night before. The Klook voucher moves freely between Wednesday, Thursday and Friday.

Old tram
If you didn't ride it on Wednesday night, swap it in after the egg tart stop and take the ferry home from Wan Chai.

30 Friday
Hong Kong

Pool, yum cha, Ozone at sunset, then departure

Late checkout is confirmed to 18:00, so the room is yours all day. A pool morning, yum cha, a spare window for anything missed, a slow pack and shower, Ozone at sunset, dinner, then a taxi at 20:45.

09:00	Lounge breakfast	
09:45	Sheraton pool	Optional. The best sun of the day.
12:00	Quick change, head out	
12:30	Yum cha lunch	Dim sum is a daytime meal and most places stop about 15:00. If lunch slips, an all-day dim sum place can stand in for dinner.
14:00	Spare window	About two hours for anything missed. Central by Star Ferry, M+ and the West Kowloon waterfront, or Nathan Road.
16:15	Back at the hotel, pack and shower	No rush. Ask at the desk whether checkout can go later still.
17:20	Check out	You have until 18:00. Leaving now catches the sunset at Ozone. Suitcases go to the concierge.
17:40	Ozone at the Ritz-Carlton To book	Short taxi to ICC, 118th floor. Sunset at 17:50, then the lights. Open from 16:00. No flip flops, and no open shoes or sleeveless tops for men.
19:15	Dinner	At Elements below Ozone, or back in Tsim Sha Tsui close to the bags.
20:30	Collect bags at the Sheraton	
20:45	Taxi to the airport	30 to 40 minutes at that hour.
21:30	Check in at the Cathay desks	Terminal 1. Three hours before departure.
00:30	**CX105 departs for Melbourne** Booked	Saturday 31 October, Terminal 1. Lands Melbourne Terminal 2 at 12:30.

Latest safe timing
A taxi at 21:15 puts you at the airport by 22:00, which is 2.5 hours before departure.

If you missed the Peak or Ngong Ping
It takes the morning in place of the pool. The Peak has Klook Fast Track on a Friday, and the Ngong Ping voucher works any day. Be back by 16:15.

If Ozone was Thursday
Then tonight is free: a harbourfront drink, a longer dinner, or more time in the room.

If Friday is wet or grey
Skip the pool. M+ and the West Kowloon waterfront is the indoor option, and the room is yours until 18:00.

Optional swaps in Hong Kong

The plan above is the default. Wednesday, Thursday and Friday are interchangeable, so match them to the forecast once you arrive. Put the Peak and the Big Buddha on the clearest days. Put the pool time on the hottest ones. Only the bookings tie a plan to a day.

Ngong Ping on Friday, instead of Thursday
Replaces the Friday pool and yum cha. First cable car at 10:00, back at the hotel by about 15:30 to pack and shower. The Klook voucher moves with you.
Costs the easy last morning. A big day before a red-eye.

Dragon's Back hike, then Shek O or Big Wave Bay beach
Replaces the Big Buddha on Thursday morning, from 08:30 to about 14:30.
Costs the cable car. Join Thursday's plan at the Sheung Wan shops at 15:00.

M+ and West Kowloon waterfront
Replaces any pool block on a wet or grey day.
Costs pool time. A short taxi from the hotel.

Checklist

Set up at home

- [ ] Offline Google Maps areas for Tokyo, Kyoto, Osaka and Hong Kong
- [ ] Google Translate with Japanese and Chinese downloaded for offline use
- [ ] Airline, booking, Klook and Ubigi apps installed and logged in
- [ ] Banking apps working with Face ID, and international transactions enabled
- [ ] Travel insurance policy, passports and booking confirmations saved offline
- [ ] Licence and International Driving Permit photographed, as a backup only
- [ ] Hotel names and addresses screenshotted in Japanese and Chinese (How-to 1)
- [ ] Ubigi eSIM installed, one each. Smartstart starts it in Hong Kong on Fri 16 (How-to 2)
- [ ] Suica and Octopus in both Apple Wallets, Suica topped up
- [ ] Visit Japan Web registered for both, tax-free QR on, passports scanned

Book or confirm before you fly

- [ ] **Shibuya.** International Driving Permit, 1949 Geneva Convention version, for Street Kart
- [ ] **Shibuya.** Street Kart: meeting point, arrival time, and rebooking terms in case it moves to Sun 25 or Mon 26
- [ ] **Shibuya.** Shibuya Sky Monday and Tuesday slots: check the cancellation or change terms
- [ ] **Shibuya.** Optional, on TableCheck: Ninja Tokyo Sat 17 19:00, Sushi Hatsume Sun 18 19:30
- [ ] **Kyoto.** Gion dinner for Fri 23, 18:30. Pontochō on Wed 21 is walk-in
- [ ] **Hibiya.** Ask the Blossom about pre-registering for Sat 24, so arrival is keys only
- [ ] **Hibiya.** Confirm where and when the Seascape wristbands are collected on Sat 24
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Confirm all four flights in the Cathay app: CX104, CX524, CX543, CX105
- [ ] **Hibiya.** Optional: Daikoku car meet tour for Sun 25, about 20:00, hotel pickup
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Cynthia: check whether the Agoda booking includes an airport pickup on Tue 27
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Ngong Ping 360 Crystal cabin vouchers on Klook, good on any day to 31 October
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Pick a yum cha place for Fri 30 lunch, 12:30
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Hong Kong dollars for the airport taxi on arrival

Decide with the Tokyo forecast

- [ ] **Shibuya.** Pick the Shibuya Sky day, then cancel or change the other two slots
- [ ] **Shibuya.** Give the better weather day of Mon 19 and Tue 20 to Tsukiji and Yokohama
- [ ] **Shibuya.** A wet morning: move teamLab Borderless forward (How-to 8)

Decide with the Hong Kong forecast

- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Aqua Luna: confirm the 19:30 sailing on Tue 27 is running, then book. +852 2116 8821
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Peak Tram one-way up, about 15:45 on the clearest evening (Wed 28 by default)
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Dinner in Central or SoHo for the same evening as the Peak, 19:30
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Pick the Ngong Ping day for the voucher, first car at 10:00 (Thu 29 by default)
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Ozone at the Ritz-Carlton: choose Thursday or Friday by the cloud, then book

On the ground

- [ ] **Shibuya.** Sat 17 at Narita: scan the landing sticker QR into Visit Japan Web, then Narita Express tickets on a train that stops at Shibuya
- [ ] **Shibuya.** Sat 17: ask Sequence for early check-in at the desk. Free; they hold the bags
- [ ] **Shibuya.** Tue 20: book the 06:30 taxi to Shinagawa for Wednesday morning
- [ ] **Kyoto.** Wed 21: Kintetsu seat times to Nara and back, and JR times to Osaka for Thursday
- [ ] **Hibiya.** Sat 24: ask the Blossom about guest laundry (How-to 17)
- [ ] **Hibiya.** Mon 26: settle the bill, and check the 06:38 Asakusa line train to Haneda
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Tue 27: ask the Sheraton whether pool sessions need booking, and the club lounge hours
- [ ] **Hong Kong.** Fri 30: ask whether checkout can go later than 18:00, and confirm bags are held until 20:30

Tips

Small things that make the days easier, in the order you will need them. Japan first, Hong Kong at the end.

Data
The eSIM gives 30GB at full speed, then slows right down. Use hotel wifi for photo backups. See How-to 2.

Umbrellas and wet gear
Use the umbrella stand or the plastic sleeve at shop doors. Clear umbrellas are cheap at any convenience store. Pack a light rain jacket each.

Power
A power bank and a USB-C cable each. Charge phones, power banks and AirPods every night.

Maps on luggage days
Turn on the accessible or step-free route option in the maps app. It finds the lifts and avoids stairs.

Luggage and lockers
Coin lockers at every big station take Suica. Large sizes fill by mid morning, so use a staffed counter for suitcases. Before any bag is handed over, take out passports, wallets, chargers and medication.

Creased clothes
Convenience stores and Don Quijote sell wrinkle release spray (シワ取りスプレー). Spray, smooth with your hands and hang for a few minutes. Easier than finding an iron.

Trains
Phones on silent, no calls, bags off your back in a crowd. Queue on the platform markings and let people off first.

Crowded trains
Carry hand sanitiser. A mask is useful if you prefer one in crowded indoor spaces.

Escalators
Stand on the left in Tokyo, on the right in Osaka, and on the right in Hong Kong.

Crossing
Wait for the green man, even on an empty street. Nobody jaywalks.

Taxi doors
The rear left door opens and closes by itself in Japan. Leave it alone.

Cash and coins
About ¥5,000 to ¥10,000 each a day is plenty. Small restaurants, market stalls, temple entry and shrine charms are often cash only. Keep a coin purse of ¥10, ¥50, ¥100 and ¥500 for machines and temples. Top up as you go: 7-Eleven, Lawson, FamilyMart and Japan Post ATMs take foreign cards, most with English.

The right mix of yen
Notes are ¥1,000, ¥5,000 and ¥10,000. Keep three or four ¥1,000s each for stalls, temples and taxis; break ¥10,000s at convenience stores, not small shops. ATMs give mostly ¥10,000s, so ask for an amount like ¥19,000 to get smaller notes. Most useful coins: ¥100 and ¥500 for machines, a few ¥10 and ¥5 for shrines.

Cards and cash
Carry two cards, kept separately. Leave one card and some emergency cash in the room safe. Never keep both phones, wallets and cards in one bag. If an ATM or card machine offers to charge you in AUD, choose yen.

Money tray
Put cash or card on the small tray at the till, not into the hand. Change comes back the same way.

No tipping in Japan
Not expected anywhere, and it can cause confusion. A thank you is enough.

Ticket machine restaurants
Many ramen and casual places have a machine at the door. Pick, pay, then hand the ticket to the staff.

Eating and walking
Eat at the stall or standing to one side, not on the move. Same on local trains, other than the Shinkansen. A lidded takeaway coffee on the go is fine in the city, but markets and temple lanes often ask you not to, so stand aside there. Bins are rare, so plan to carry the cup.

Chopsticks
Never stand them upright in rice or pass food from chopstick to chopstick. Rest them on the holder.

Litter
Public bins are rare. Carry a small bag and take rubbish back to the hotel or a convenience store.

Cold lockers
Some stations and department stores have refrigerated lockers. Ask for an ice pack when buying food to carry.

Passports
Carry the physical passports on shopping days: Sat 17, Mon 19, Thu 22 and Sun 25. A photo on the phone is not accepted for tax-free.

Fitting rooms
Put on the thin face cover (フェイスカバー) the shop gives you before pulling on a top, so makeup does not mark the clothes. Shoes off at the fitting room step.

Tax-free
Japan's tax is already in the price. Spend ¥5,000 or more before tax in one store, show your physical passports, and the tax isn't charged: you save the 10% tax on most goods (8% on take-away food and soft drinks), about 9% and 7% off the shelf price. Food bought tax-free goes in a sealed bag: keep it sealed until you leave Japan. See How-to 4.

No fakes into Japan
Since October 2022, bringing counterfeit or replica branded goods into Japan is illegal even for personal use, in your luggage or by post. That covers bags, watches, shoes and clothing. Customs can seize and destroy them on arrival, with no compensation. Leave any knockoffs at home. The vintage luxury stores sell authenticated pieces, so keep the receipts.

Street Kart
Wear fully closed shoes. Take the physical licence card, the physical International Driving Permit and passports. Photos are not accepted.

Shrines and temples
Bow once at the torii gate and walk to the side of the path, not down the middle. Rinse hands at the basin. At a shrine: bow twice, clap twice, bow once. At a temple, no clapping.

The ¥5 coin
Called go-en, which also means "good connection", so it is the lucky offering at a shrine. Keep a few aside.

Bowing
A small nod back is all that is needed.

Shoes and socks
Shoes come off wherever there is a step up or a rack at the door: temples, some restaurants, fitting rooms. Wear good socks, and carry a clean spare pair on temple and shrine days.

Nara deer
Buy the crackers, show empty hands when you run out, and keep maps and paper out of reach. They bow, and they also nip.

Geisha and maiko
No photos in Gion without permission, and keep off the private lanes. There are fines.

Massage
A head spa, foot or body massage near each hotel is listed in How-to 21. Book head spas a day or two ahead.

Hong Kong: cash
Octopus covers trains, buses and most shops. For cash, carry HK$20, HK$50 and HK$100 notes. Taxis and small stalls often cannot change HK$500 or HK$1,000. Some red taxis are still cash only.

Hong Kong: tipping
Restaurants add 10% service. Round up for taxis. Small notes for porters.

Hong Kong: MTR
No eating or drinking past the gates. There are fines.

Hong Kong: trams
Board at the back, pay with Octopus at the front as you get off. Upper deck, front seat.

Appendix: how-to

Step by step, for the moments with bags, tickets or a clock. The day pages point here by number.

How-to 1. Phones and power

- Download offline Google Maps areas for Tokyo, Kyoto, Osaka and Hong Kong.
- Save flight, hotel and the main booking confirmations offline.
- Screenshot each hotel name and address in the local script, from the booking confirmation, to show a driver if a phone dies or data misbehaves.
- sequence MIYASHITA PARK, Shibuya: 東京都渋谷区神宮前6-20-10 MIYASHITA PARK North.
- sequence KYOTO GOJO: 京都府京都市下京区五条烏丸町409.
- THE BLOSSOM HIBIYA, Tokyo: 東京都港区新橋1-1-13.
- Sheraton Hong Kong, 香港喜來登酒店: 九龍尖沙咀彌敦道20號.
- A power bank and a USB-C cable each. Every night, charge phones, power banks and AirPods.
- Keep one phone able to receive Australian SMS for banking and two-factor codes.

How-to 2. eSIM and wifi

- Ubigi Best Asia Unlimited, 15 days, AU$78 each. One for each phone. The 15 days run to the evening of Sat 31, covering the flight home.
- Install both eSIMs at home on wifi, then leave the Ubigi line switched off. Best Asia stays waiting to start, so nothing is used.
- On landing in Hong Kong, Fri 16 at 21:45: Settings, Mobile, Ubigi line, turn it on. Ubigi Data Roaming on. Mobile Data set to Ubigi.
- Australian SIM: Data Roaming off, but keep the line on for SMS and two-factor codes. The Ubigi app should then show the plan as active.
- Covers Japan (KDDI, Docomo) and Hong Kong (Smartone) with no change. 30GB at full speed, then 2 Mbps; track it in the Ubigi app, top up there if needed.
- Phone settings: Auto-Join on for hotel wifi, Wi-Fi Assist off, photo backup on wifi only.

How-to 3. Suica and Octopus

- Both are already in your Apple Wallets. Tap the phone at the gate, no need to unlock it with Express Mode on.
- Top up in Wallet with Apple Pay. Keep about ¥2,000 on Suica.
- Suica works on trains, metros and buses across Tokyo, Kyoto and Osaka, and at convenience stores, lockers and vending machines.
- It does not pay for Shinkansen or Narita Express tickets.
- Octopus does the same job in Hong Kong: MTR, Star Ferry, trams, buses and convenience stores.
- Spend the Suica balance airside at Haneda.

How-to 4. Tax-free shopping

- Take the physical passports. The shop scans the entry sticker. A photo is not accepted.
- Spend ¥5,000 or more before tax in one store on the same day. Food and other goods can be added together to reach it. Look for the Tax-Free sign, or the tax-free counter in a department store.
- Prices already include Japan's tax. Tax-free means it isn't charged: 10% on most goods and alcohol, 8% on take-away food and soft drinks. That is about 9% and 7% off the shelf price.
- Restaurant meals are never tax-free. Department stores refund at a separate counter, less about 1.5%.
- Food, drinks and cosmetics are sealed in a bag. Keep it sealed until you leave Japan.
- Tax-free QR, at home: in Visit Japan Web, personal details, turn on "Use tax-free QR code" and scan both passports with the phone camera.
- Tax-free QR, at Narita: immigration sticks a landing permission sticker with a QR in each passport. Check you both get one. Then in Visit Japan Web open the tax-free section, scan each sticker, and the QR is ready. Show it live at the till; carry passports anyway.
- Back in Australia: AUD 900 of goods, 2.25 L of alcohol and 25 cigarettes each. Declare all food and wood. Undeclared items risk a fine of about AUD 626.
- This at-the-till system runs to 31 October, so it covers the trip. It changes on 1 November.

How-to 5. Narita Express ticket, Sat 17

- After customs, follow the signs for Railways down to the basement level.
- Buy at the JR East Travel Service Centre or a JR ticket machine with the N'EX logo. Every seat is reserved, so the ticket gives you a car and seat. No need to book from home.
- Ask for Shibuya. Check the train on your ticket stops at Shibuya, as not every service does.
- About 75 to 80 minutes. Big bags go in the racks at the end of the car.
- Pay by card. Suica does not cover the express fare.

How-to 6. Shibuya Station to the hotel, Sat 17

- Leave by the Hachikō exit, the one for the dog statue and the Scramble Crossing.
- Keep the rail line on your right and walk north along it to Miyashita Park, the long building with the park on its roof.
- Sequence Miyashita Park is the tower at the far, northern end. About 7 minutes, flat.
- Take the lift to the lobby on the 4th floor. Leave the bags and ask about early check-in.

How-to 7. Shibuya Sky, what to leave behind

- Not allowed on the rooftop: bags, backpacks and pouches, hats and caps, tripods and selfie sticks, earbuds and headphones, food and drink, and anything loose that could blow away.
- Fine to take: a phone, and a camera on a strap.
- Everything else goes into the free lockers on the 46th floor, which means a queue on the way in and again on the way out.
- So drop it all at the hotel first, seven minutes away. Wear pockets that close. Take phones, the booking QR code and one card.

How-to 8. Moving teamLab for wet weather

- Booked for Mon 26 at 08:30. The date or time can be changed up to three times.
- Open the booking from the confirmation email and choose the change option.
- Good places for it: any wet morning on the Shibuya leg, or Sunday 25 morning in place of the gardens.
- From Shibuya it is about 30 minutes by metro to Azabudai Hills, or 15 to 20 minutes by taxi.
- If it moves, Monday 26 starts in Asakusa about 10:00.

How-to 9. Omotesando and Aoyama store hours

- Amore Vintage (Omotesando and Aoyama), Vintage Qoo, Brand Collect and ALLU all open at 11:00.
- Casanova Vintage opens at 12:00, so leave it until last.
- Amore, Qoo and Casanova trade until 20:00. Take the physical passports for tax-free.

How-to 10. While the stores are on, for G

- The window is 11:00 to 14:00 on the Shinjuku day, then lunch together in Omotesando.
- Roppongi design loop: Chiyoda line from Omotesando, one stop to Nogizaka. 21_21 Design Sight (10:00 to 19:00, closed Tuesdays and between shows) and the National Art Center. The Mori Art Museum is shut in October; Tokyo City View below it is open.
- Shibuya Parco, a short walk from the hotel: Nintendo Tokyo, the Pokémon Center, the Capcom Store and the Jump Shop, all on one floor, plus the rooftop.
- Harakado, at the Harajuku end of Omotesando: design shops, a rooftop, and Kosugi-yu, an old-style bath in the basement. Tokyu Plaza opposite has the mirrored escalator and a free rooftop terrace.
- Ura-Harajuku: the back lanes either side of Cat Street, for streetwear and sneaker shops.
- Gym session: Gold's Gym Harajuku sells one-day passes, but it shuts on the third Monday of the month, which is the 19th. Fine on a Tuesday.
- Sauna: Shibuya Saunas, five minutes from Shibuya Station. 08:00 to midnight, about ¥3,200 on a weekday for 2.5 hours, tattoo friendly.
- Sento: Kairyo-yu, nearest Ebisu Station. Opens at 12:00, ¥600 plus ¥550 for the sauna.

How-to 11. Omoide Yokochō, Mon 19

- Memory Lane: two narrow alleys beside the west exit of Shinjuku Station, with about 60 tiny yakitori counters and bars under red lanterns.
- Arrive about 17:30. By 19:00 the popular counters are full.
- Pick any counter with two free seats. Order a drink each and a few skewers, then move on. Two or three places is the normal way to do it.
- Many counters add a small seating charge, a few hundred yen each, and bring a small snack you did not order. It is called otoshi (お通し): that is the charge, so it is normal, not a mistake.
- Check the menu and prices before you sit. If none are posted, ask, or pick a counter that shows them. Counters are tiny and best for two.
- Carry cash. Some counters do not take cards.
- It is smoky from the grills, and some counters allow smoking.
- This is the place to eat. Golden Gai, later, is tiny bars for drinking.
- Golden Gai, about 20:00: around 200 tiny bars across six alleys. Look for an English menu or sign on the door, which means visitors are welcome.
- Some bars are for locals or regulars only. If the sign or the barman says so, move on.
- Take cash. Most bars charge a cover of roughly ¥500 to ¥1,500 each before the first drink, usually posted at the door.
- Many bars do not allow photos inside, and some lanes ask for none at all.
- Kabukichō on the way: ignore touts, and never follow anyone off the street into a bar.

How-to 12. Hotel to the Shinkansen, Wed 21

- The night before: pack, settle the bill, and ask the front desk to book a taxi for 06:30.
- 05:55 wake. 06:20 check out. 06:30 taxi to Shinagawa Station, Kōnan exit, which is the Shinkansen side. About 20 to 25 minutes.
- About 07:00 at Shinagawa. Buy ekiben and coffee inside the Shinkansen gates.
- On the platform by 07:40. Nozomi 13 leaves at 07:55. Car 9, seats 16-C and 16-D. Bags go in the oversized baggage space behind the last row.
- Fallback if no taxi comes: JR Yamanote line from Shibuya to Shinagawa, about 13 minutes, leaving by 06:45.

How-to 13. Kyoto Station, bags and the walk, Wed 21

- Use Crosta Kyoto, the staffed baggage counter on level B1, directly below the JR Central Gate on the north, Kyoto Tower side. Open 08:00 to 20:00. ¥1,000 per bag per day. Not the Hachijō gate counter by the Shinkansen, which shuts at 18:00.
- Before the bags go over the counter, take out: passports, wallets and cards, phones, chargers and power bank, medication, a warm layer, and anything valuable or fragile. Valuables are not accepted in stored bags.
- From the Nozomi at 10:00: go out through the Shinkansen gates and follow the signs for the Central Gate and the Karasuma side, along the upper walkway across the tracks. About 7 minutes with the bags.
- At the Central Gate, take the escalator down to B1. The counter is behind the escalators, signed for baggage. Hand the bags over, pay, and keep the receipt. You need it to collect.
- For Nara: back up the escalator and through the station's central passage to the Kintetsu gates on the south side, about 10 minutes (How-to 24).
- Coming back about 17:25: out through the Central Gate, down to B1, collect with the receipt. With a 20:00 close, a late train is not a problem.
- Option: Crosta delivers to Kyoto hotels for ¥1,500 a bag if dropped by 14:00. Ask the hotel first.
- To sequence KYOTO GOJO: out the north side, the Kyoto Tower side, then straight north up Karasuma-dōri to Gojō. About 15 minutes, flat. Or take the Karasuma subway line one stop to Gojō, then walk 3 minutes. Or a taxi from the north rank.

How-to 14. Osaka there and back, Thu 22

- Out: one subway stop from Gojō to Kyoto Station, or a 15 minute walk. Leave the hotel at 07:00.
- JR special rapid from Kyoto to Osaka Station, about 30 minutes. They run every 15 minutes and Suica works. No seat booking.
- At Osaka, change to the JR Osaka Loop Line, outer loop, to Osakajōkōen. About 10 minutes. The castle park is at the exit.
- After the castle, walk to Tanimachi 4-chōme on its west side and buy the Enjoy Eco Card day pass at the metro ticket machine. About ¥820 on a weekday. It covers the Osaka Metro, not JR.
- Back: Midōsuji line from Namba to Umeda, four stops. Walk through to JR Osaka Station.
- JR special rapid to Kyoto, about 30 minutes. Then the subway one stop to Gojō, or walk.
- Leaving Namba at 21:30 puts you home about 22:45. The last trains are after 23:30, but check the night before.

How-to 15. Dōtonbori canal boat, Thu 22

- The Tombori River Cruise leaves from the canal beside the Don Quijote building.
- Buy tickets at the booth when you arrive in Dōtonbori at 18:30, for a boat after dark. They sell by time slot.
- About 20 minutes on the water under the neon.
- The Glico Running Man photo platform is at the Nanohana cosmetics shop, directly opposite the sign.
- Times and price not yet checked. Skip it without regret if the queue is long.

How-to 16. Kyoto back to Tokyo, Sat 24

- Check out and leave the hotel at 10:30. Walk straight down Karasuma-dōri, about 15 minutes, or take the subway one stop.
- 11:15 at Kyoto Station. Ekiben and coffee, then through the Shinkansen gates.
- Nozomi 16 leaves at 12:01. Car 9, seats 1-C and 1-D. Fuji is on the left.
- 14:15 Tokyo Station. Follow the Yaesu exit signs to the taxi rank. Ten to fifteen minutes to the Blossom.

How-to 17. Laundry, Sun 25

- By Sunday 25 you are a week in. Three good slots: Friday 23 evening in Kyoto, Sunday 25 morning at the Blossom, which is the easiest, or Monday 26 before dinner.
- The Blossom has a guest laundry with only a few machines, so go early. Not confirmed for sequence KYOTO GOJO, so ask at check-in there.
- A wash and dry takes about 90 minutes and a few hundred yen. Have ¥100 coins ready.
- No machines, or all busy: ask the desk for the nearest coin laundry.
- Hotel laundry service is charged per item and usually has to be handed in by mid morning for same-day return. Worth it for a few pieces only.
- Last chance: the Sheraton in Hong Kong, by laundry service.

How-to 18. Train to Haneda, Tue 27

- Monday night: pack, settle the bill, and check the first trains in the maps app.
- 05:45 wake. 06:22 leave the hotel and walk to Shimbashi Station, about 8 minutes. Go down to the Toei Asakusa line, platform 1.
- 06:38 Airport Rapid Limited Express, direct to Haneda Airport Terminal 3. About 25 minutes. Suica works.
- Backup: the 06:45 Express, also direct.
- Do not board a train bound for Nishi-magome. It does not go to the airport.
- If anything looks wrong, take a taxi from the hotel rank. About 25 minutes.

How-to 19. Peak Tram

- Book a standard one-way ticket up, for about 15:45 on the clearest evening. Klook Fast Track runs Friday to Sunday only.
- The lower terminus is on Garden Road in Central, 15 minutes uphill from the ferry or a short taxi. Sit on the right going up.
- At the top, walk Lugard Road, about 20 minutes each way, for the best free view. Stay through sunset at 17:50.
- Taxi down from the rank by the Peak Galleria. Tram seats face backwards on the way down.

How-to 20. Ngong Ping 360 voucher

- Buy two Crystal cabin vouchers on Klook before flying. Non-refundable, but good on any day up to 31 October. If wind closes it, the voucher moves to another day.
- Pick the day from the forecast the night before. Clear and calm is what you want.
- MTR to Tung Chung, about 50 minutes from Tsim Sha Tsui with one change. The cable car terminal is a few minutes from exit B.
- Be there for the first car at 10:00. Follow the signs for Klook or prepaid vouchers, and join the Crystal cabin queue.

How-to 21. Massage near each hotel

- Head spas are small, appointment-only salons: book a day or two ahead. Body and foot places mostly take walk-ins. Hours from Google, October 2026; check on the day.
- Shibuya. Head spa: The Head Spa Tokyo Harajuku, about 5 minutes north of the hotel, or Head Spa Josho in Omotesando, open to 22:00. Body and foot: Body Spa Sora, east side of the station, to 23:00, or Joyful Massage Spa Shibuya, open 24 hours.
- Kyoto. Head spa: Head Spa Salon QUATRE near Shijō-Karasuma, one subway stop north, or The Head Spa Tokyo Kyoto at Shijō-Kawaramachi. Body and foot: YUMEMISHI Shijō-Karasuma, the closest, to 21:00, or Hannari near Nishiki, to 22:00.
- Hibiya and Ginza. Head spa: Head Spa ZEN, to 23:00, or Head Spa zwei HAUS, to 22:00. Body and foot: Buasai Ginza, Thai massage 5 minutes from the hotel, to midnight, or YURAGI, to midnight.
- Hong Kong. Head: Kungfu head therapy at 27 Nathan Road, two minutes from the Sheraton. Foot: Foot Lam Moon on Hankow Road, to 00:30. Body and foot: Fu Ying Massage on Granville Road, open 24 hours.

How-to 22. Footbaths in Yokohama, Tue 20 ideas

- Ideas, not bookings. The easy one, on the dusk walk: The Wharf House footbath terrace in Yamashita Park. Feet only.
- The Wharf House: ¥300 each for 30 minutes, towel ¥200. Take a number inside, often a 20 minute wait. Closed in rain. Harbour and Bay Bridge view; the Ferris wheel is faint.
- For the Ferris wheel view: Manyo Club, five minutes from the Air Cabin, has a rooftop footbath facing the wheel. Entry covers the whole spa, ¥3,600 each, in their robe.
- Manyo Club risk: tattoos are refused, apart from small ones under their stickers, up to 11 cm square. The robe covers it on the roof, but not in the shared locker room. If noticed, expect to be asked to leave, no refund.
- Ask Manyo Club first: call 0570-07-4126, or ask the hotel front desk to ring. Show them: 背中にタトゥーがあります。館内着で完全に隠れます。屋上の足湯だけ利用したいのですが、入館できますか？ (I have a tattoo on my back, fully covered by the loungewear. I only want the rooftop footbath. May I enter?)

How-to 23. Daikoku car meet, Sun 25 option

- An option, not a booking. Daikoku PA, on Yokohama's Bayshore Route, is where Japanese car fans meet at night. Only reachable by car, so book a tour (Klook or the operator).
- You ride in a JDM car such as an R34 Skyline, RX-7 or Supra with an English-speaking guide. Pickup from the Blossom, about 3 hours, tolls included. Start about 20:00; teamLab is 08:30 Monday.
- Police can close Daikoku without notice, mostly on Friday and Saturday nights. Pick a tour that moves you to another bay spot if it is shut, and check its refund terms.

How-to 24. Kyoto to Nara and back, Wed 21

- Kintetsu: south side of Kyoto Station. At the machine, buy Kintetsu Nara plus a limited express (特急) seat, about ¥1,280, 35 minutes. Board one signed 奈良.
- No seats: the direct express (急行), 45 minutes, ¥760 on Suica, hourly. In Nara, exit for Higashimuki.
- JR alternative: Miyakoji rapid from the JR gates, 45 minutes, ¥720 on Suica, then 20 minutes on foot to the park.